



NARRATIVE INTERACTIVITY CONSTRUCTING MEANING IN NONLINEAR WORLDS

by Polina Rud

1. WHEN NARRATIVE BECOMES NON LINEAR

- Linearity breaks: Communal tales fixed into heroic scripts—now we remix via art's open fields.
- Agency over authorship: Instructions invite chance; viewers weave non-linear narratives, defying stable truths.

3. WHEN NARRATIVE BECOMES PLAYABLE

- Stories emerge through rules, actions, and consequences. The player's decisions generate the narrative.
- What happens when the systems we think we're just "using" turn out to be shaping us in return? Why does interactivity always carry a hidden architecture of control?

2. WHEN NARRATIVE BECOMES NETWORKED

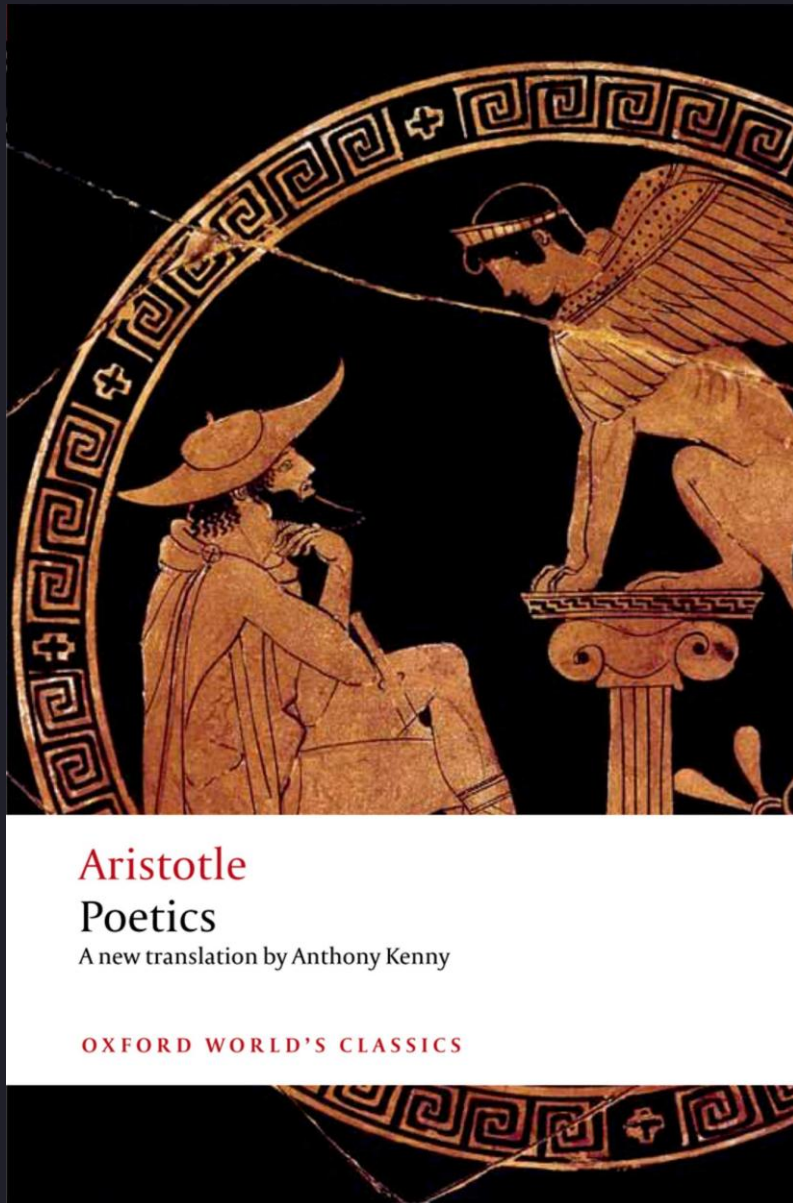
- Stories are no longer contained inside one work. They unfold through links, databases, and navigation across information.
- What happens when the interfaces we think we're just browsing start to shape how we see, think, and move through the world? Why is interactivity never as innocent as it seems?

The background is a dark, textured field of blue and white particles, resembling a nebula or a complex network of data points. The particles are more densely packed on the left side and become sparser towards the right. The overall color palette is dominated by deep blues and blacks, with bright blue highlights from the particles.

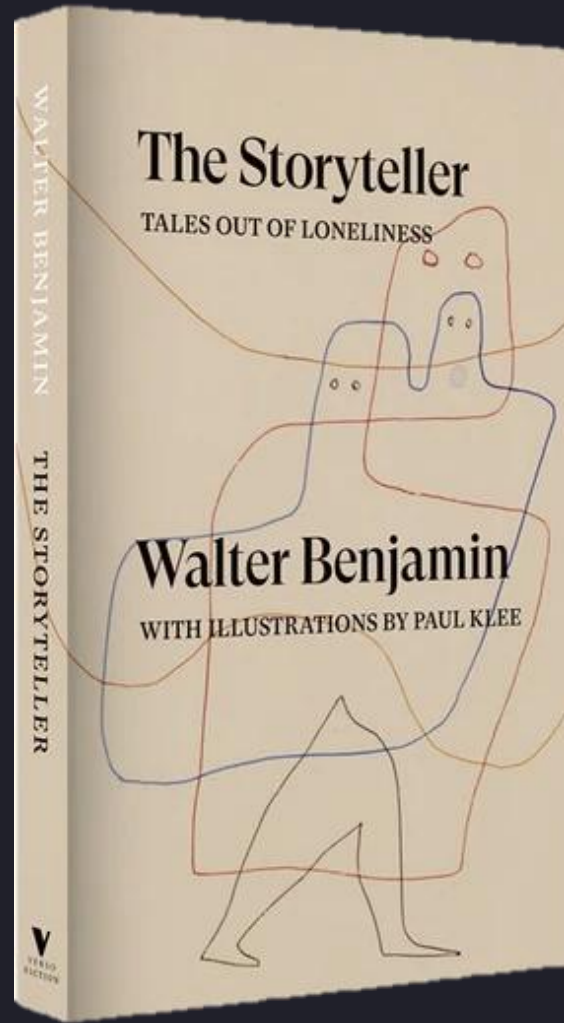
WHEN NARRATIVE BECOMES NONLINEAR

John Hull

Storytelling used to be a collective practice, where each listener was a future storyteller who might alter its meaning through communal "weaving and spinning"



Classical narrative is a cathartic spectacle, where audiences identify with the hero's anagnorisis (recognition) within a fixed plot built around exceptional figures

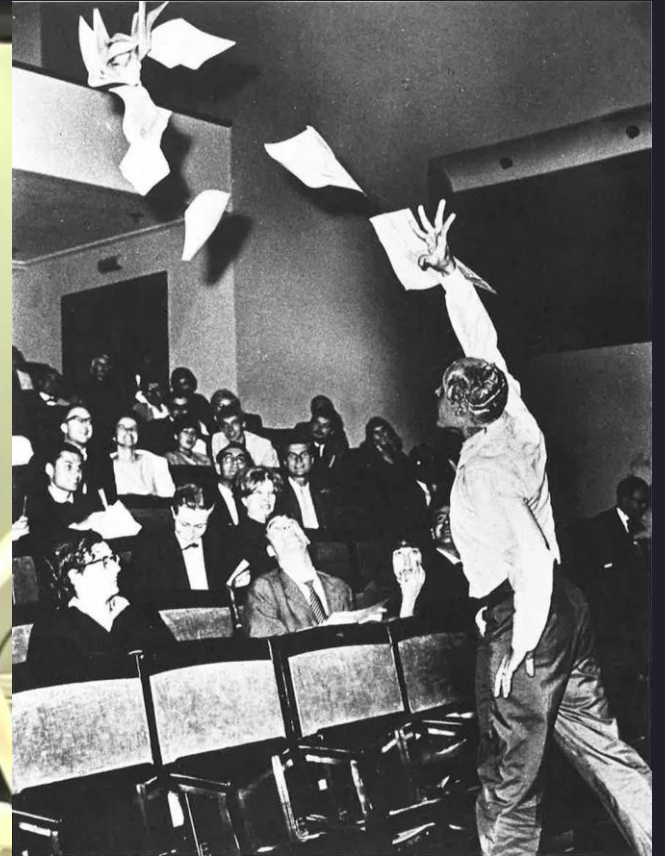


Traditional oral tales embedded listeners collectively, but novels and information culture fragmented it into isolated consumption, stripping people of the ability to exchange rich, lived narratives.



Klavierstück XI, Karlheinz Stockhausen, 1956

the piece creates a different musical trajectory with every performance, turning the performer into an active navigator of the composition



Danger Music No. 17, Dick Higgins (1962)

NOT-ACTING

Non-Matrixed
Performing

Non-Matrixed
Representation

“Received”
Acting

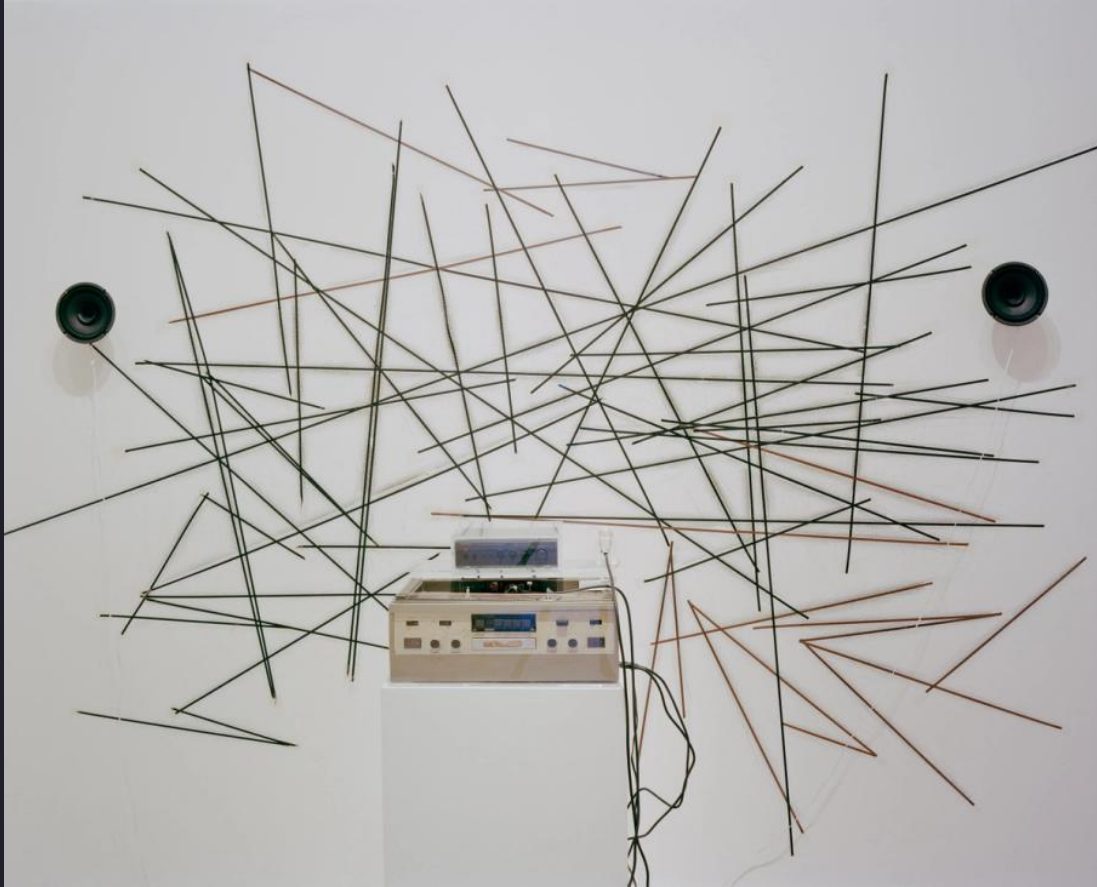
Simple
Acting

ACTING

Complex
Acting

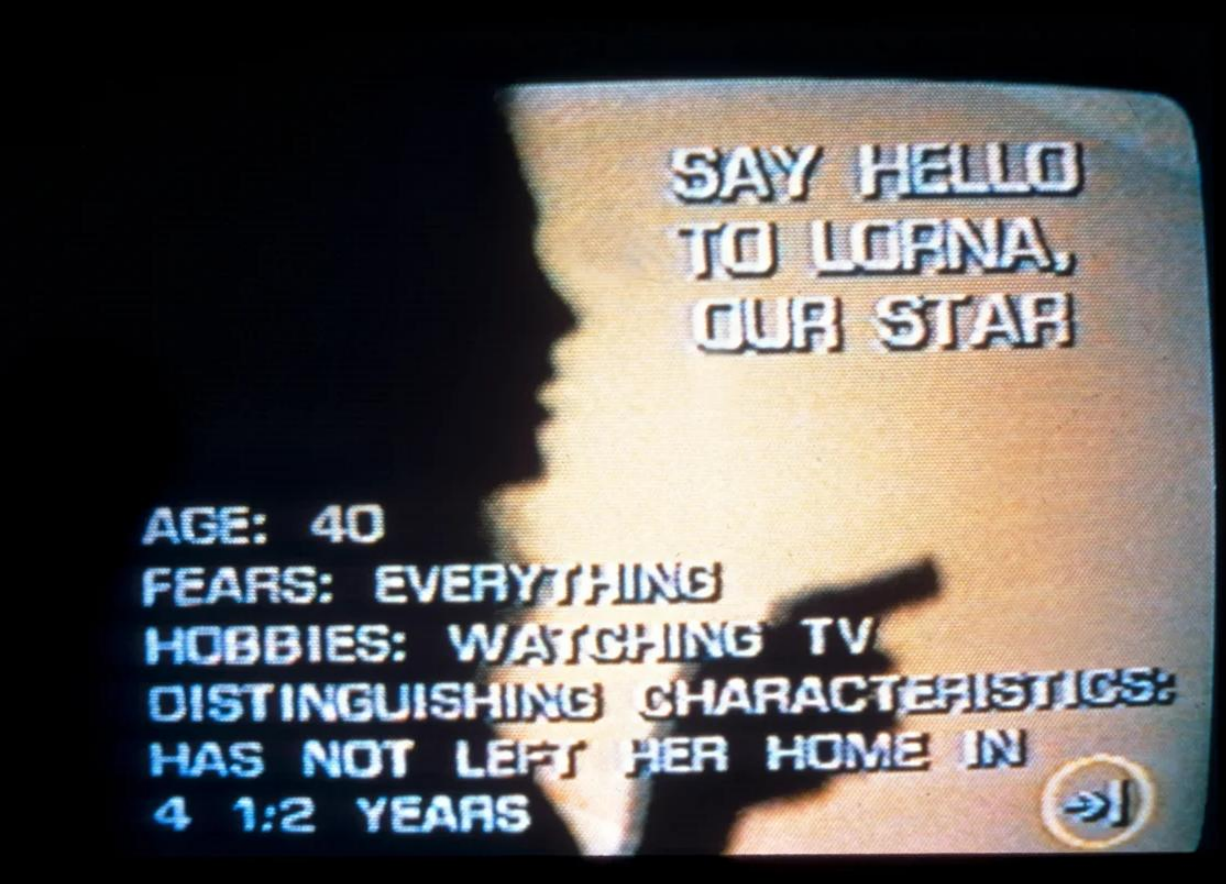
Michael Kirby

“non-matrixed performances” are works that abandon fixed structures of time, place, and character, and instead rely on flexible systems—allowing simultaneity, variability, and sequences often shaped by chance operations.



Random Access, Nam June Paik (1963)

... from a fixed recording into an open field of possibilities



Lorna, Lynn Hershman Leeson (1979–1984)

... transforming television, a passive medium, into an interactive system



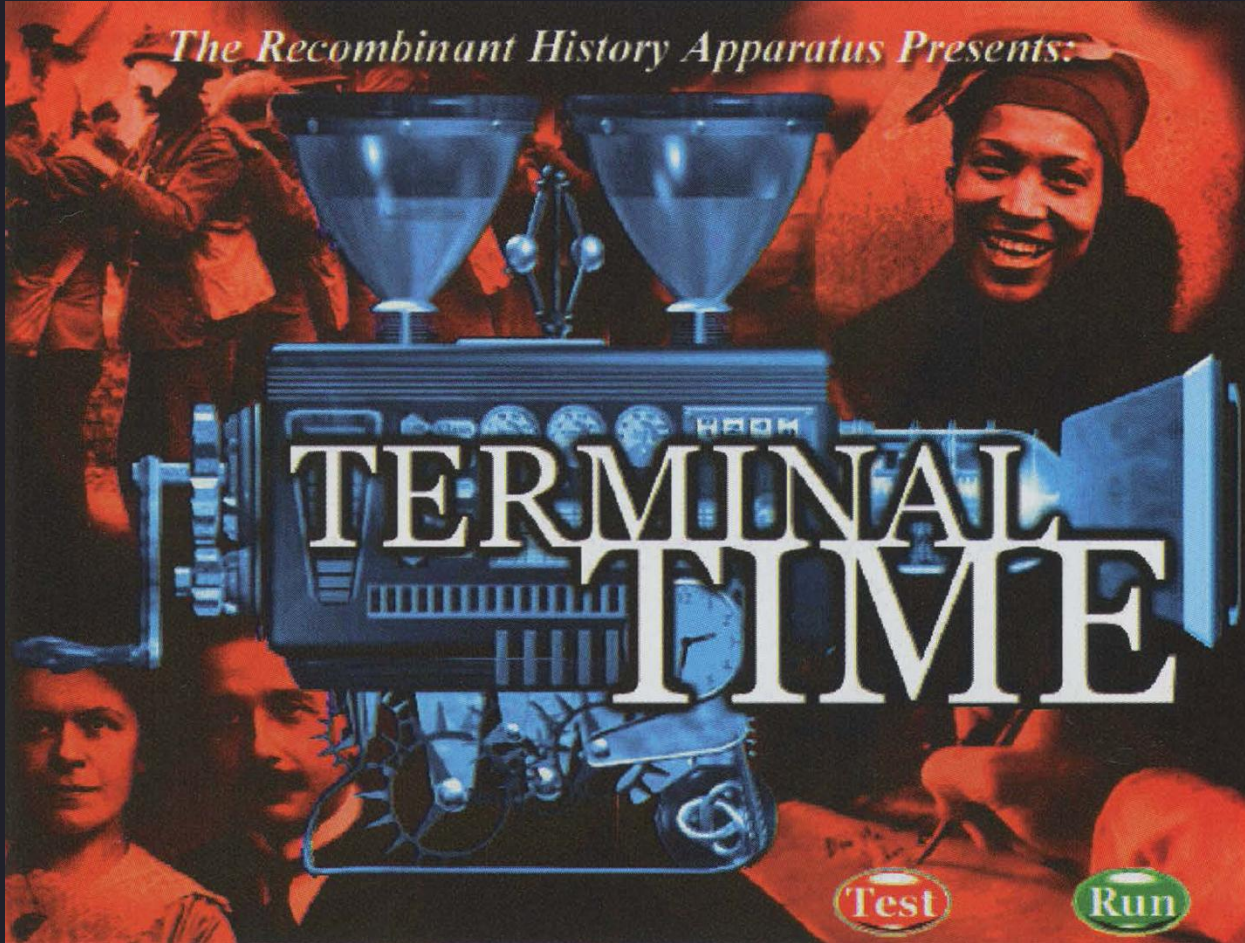
The Erl king, Grahame Weinbren (1987)

2 states: the active, when the viewer makes a selection, and the subjunctive, when the viewer becomes aware that another choice could have led to a different image.

How could you incorporate viewer **choice** into your artistic practice—offering it as agency, critiquing its illusions, or rejecting it entirely to expose what's absent in interactive structures?

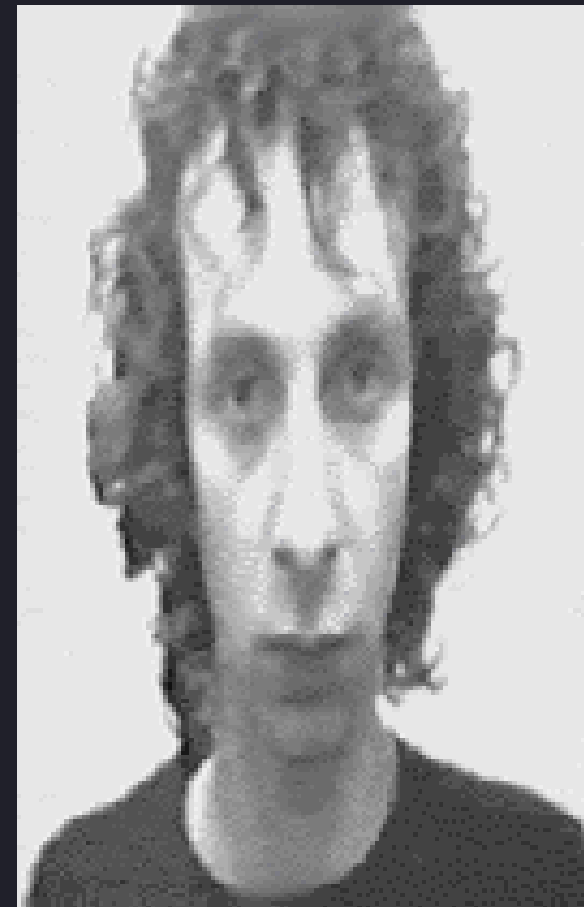
Studio Reflections





As the film progresses, the narrative exaggerates the assumptions revealed by the audience's choices, producing a version of history that mirrors their worldview.

Terminal Time, Paul Vanouse, Steffi Domike, Michael Mateas (1998–2000)



They had come
to remember the
victims of war.
But as they
stood in silence
the horror of
human pain
shattered their
peace. Women
screamed, wept
and collapsed in
terror - Today
Mon 12 Nov 90.

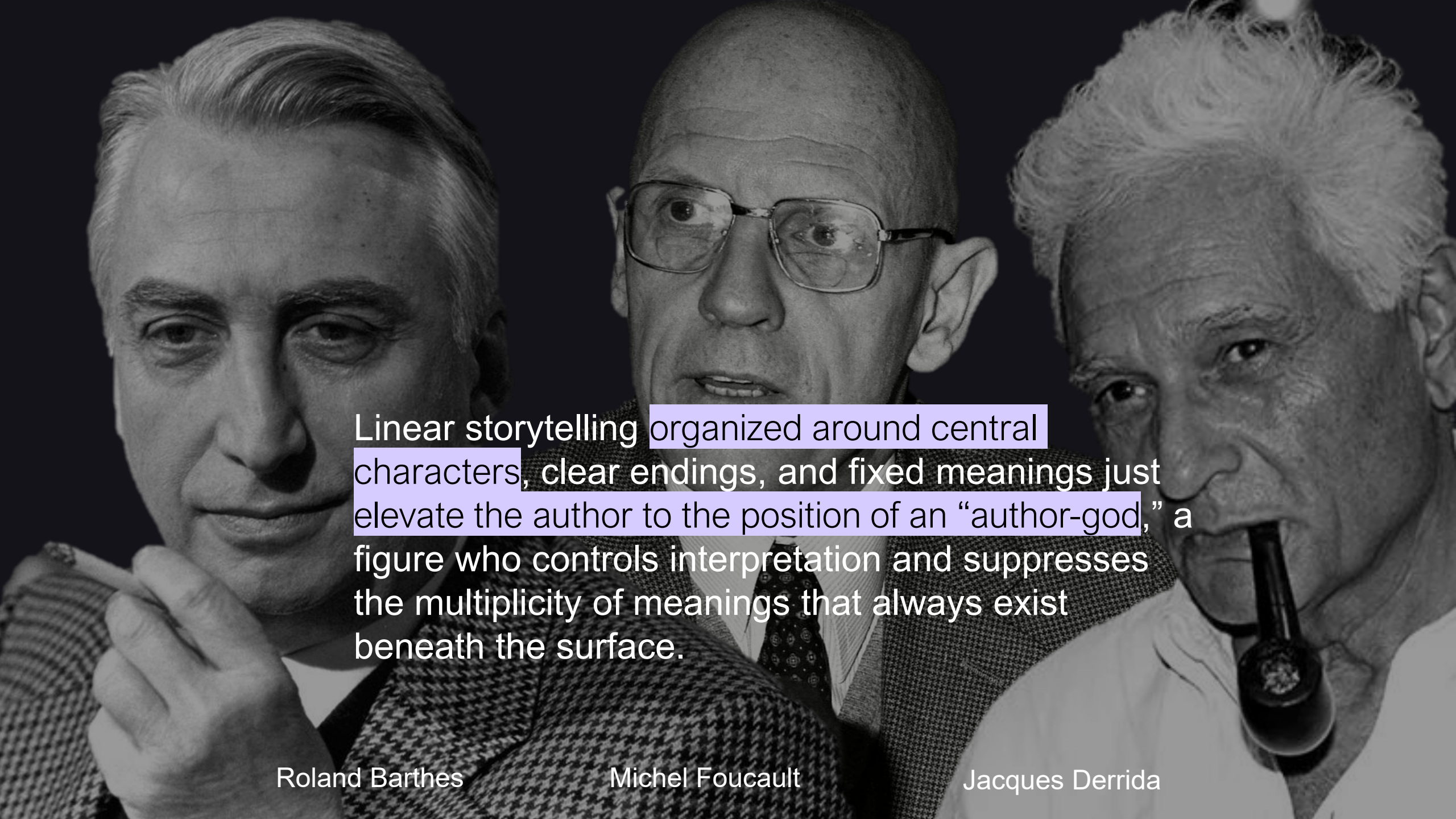
Think About the People Now, Paul Sermon (1991)



The Legible City, Jeffrey Shaw (1989)

The work is both interactive and narrative:

- the participant actively determines their path through the city,
- the unfolding texts construct a fragmented narrative about urban history and memory



Linear storytelling organized around central characters, clear endings, and fixed meanings just elevate the author to the position of an “author-god,” a figure who controls interpretation and suppresses the multiplicity of meanings that always exist beneath the surface.

Roland Barthes

Michel Foucault

Jacques Derrida

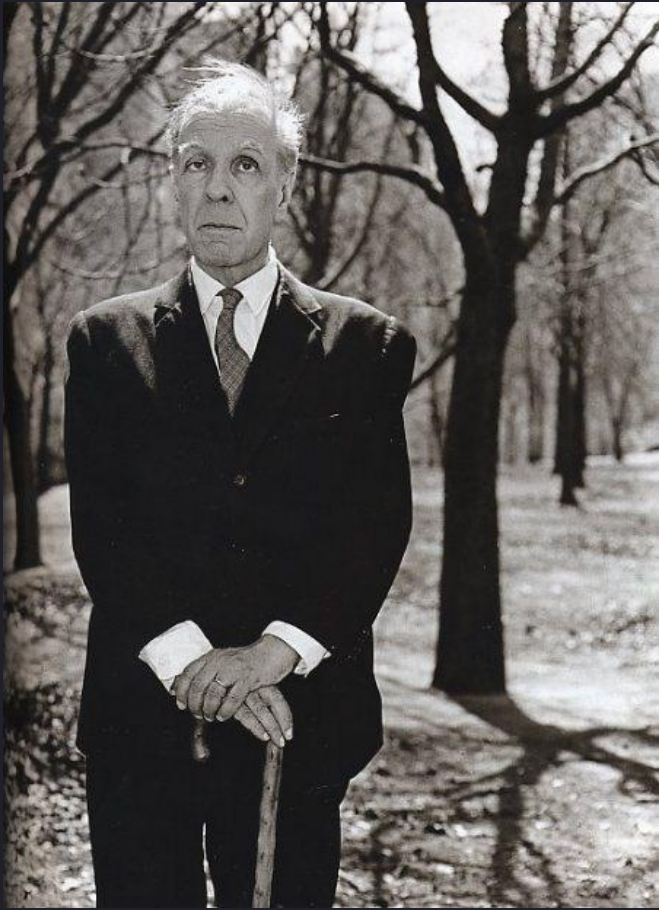
KEY TAKEAWAYS

- From communal oral weaving to fixed heroic narratives: Storytelling evolved from collective, mutable tales (pre-Aristotle) to authored, linear plots (Poetics onward), eroding listener agency—critiqued by Benjamin as modernity's isolating fragmentation.
- Performer and audience agency in experimental arts: 1950s music (Stockhausen), Fluxus anti-theater (Higgins), and non-matrixed performances introduced instructions over control, enabling chance-driven variability and real-time navigation.
- Non-linear media and interactive cinema: Paik's tactile sound fields, Hershman's remote-shaped biographies, Weinbren's editable films, and database histories (Terminal Time) transform passive consumption into viewer-assembled narratives.
- Embodied, de-centered meaning-making: Spatial works (Legible City) dissolve hero arcs and author-gods (Barthes/Foucault), exposing Derrida's unstable meanings as choice-driven, contingent constellations beyond linearity.

WHEN NARRATIVE BECOMES NETWORKED



Once we begin to question the illusion that a story can be finished, resolved, understood, a different mode of narrative becomes possible—ergodic structures: narratives that require active traversal, effort, and participation in order to unfold.



JORGE LUIS BORGES
The Garden Of
Forking Paths



As we read, we hold parallel possibilities in suspension: futures that might have happened, paths not taken, contradictory outcomes that nonetheless coexist conceptually.



proposed the concept of the rhizome to describe systems in which any point can connect to any other without hierarchical order

Félix Guattari

Gilles Deleuze

Administrator: C:\Windows\System32\cmd.exe

```
Connection-specific DNS Suffix  :  
IPv4 Address. . . . . : 100.85.42.56  
Subnet Mask . . . . . : 255.255.255.255  
Default Gateway . . . . . : 0.0.0.0
```

Ethernet adapter Local Area Connection:

```
Media State . . . . . : Media disconnected  
Connection-specific DNS Suffix  :
```

Wireless LAN adapter Wireless Network Connection:

```
Media State . . . . . : Media disconnected  
Connection-specific DNS Suffix  :
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The infrastructures that enabled early networked media were embedded in state systems, corporate platforms, and technological protocols that shaped how information circulated.



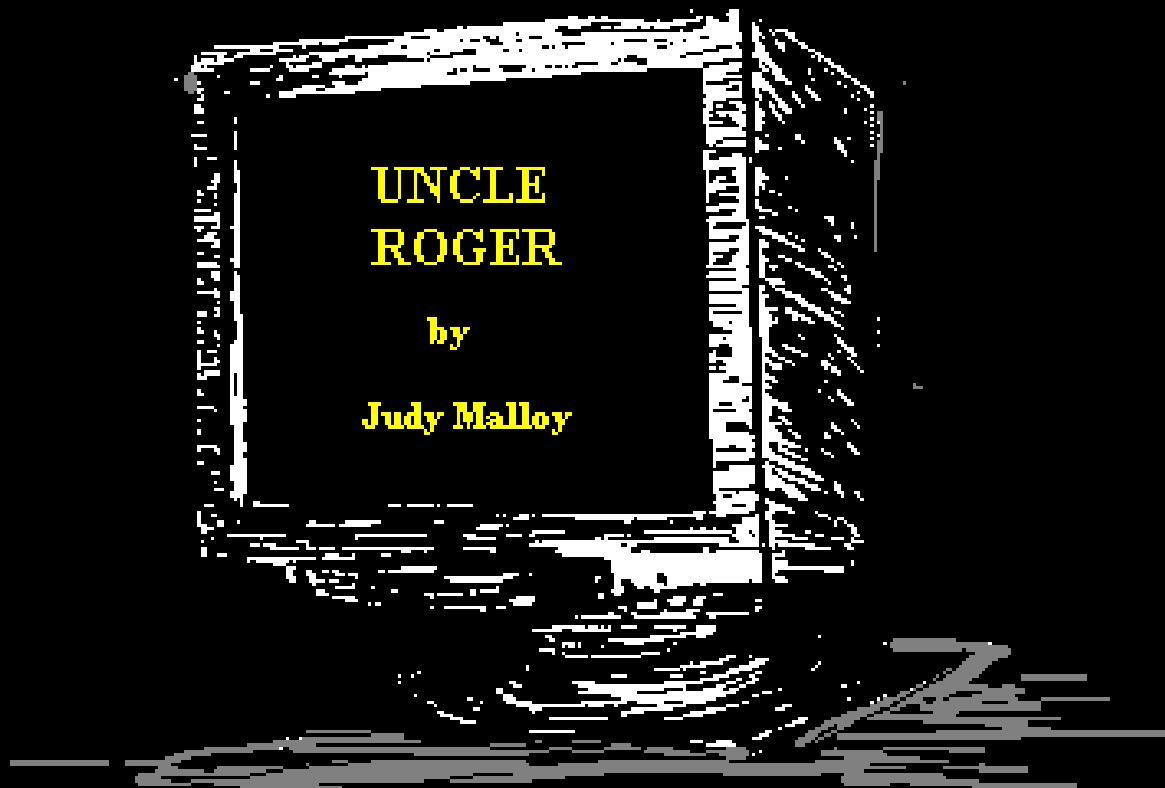
Reabracadabra, Eduardo Kac (1985)



Video texto was a text-based network launched by the state as part of a modernization project under Brazil's military dictatorship



a form of mass co-
authorship, where ordinary
users can participate in
constructing meaning



Judy Malloy: UNCLE ROGER

Woodside is a small bedroom community South of San Francisco. Although many of the Lords of Silicon Valley live closer to the Valley --in places like Los Gatos or Santa Clara -- there are some who live in Woodside. As the story begins, a party in Woodside is remembered fitfully, interspersed with the dreams of the narrator Jenny: I drank too much red wine. The Broadthrow's party is looping in my mind, nested with brief dreams and nightmares.

- 1 A Party in Woodside
- 2 The Blue Notebook
- 3 Terminals

Chose 1 2 or 3 to read the story
to exit Uncle Roger, type stop

?

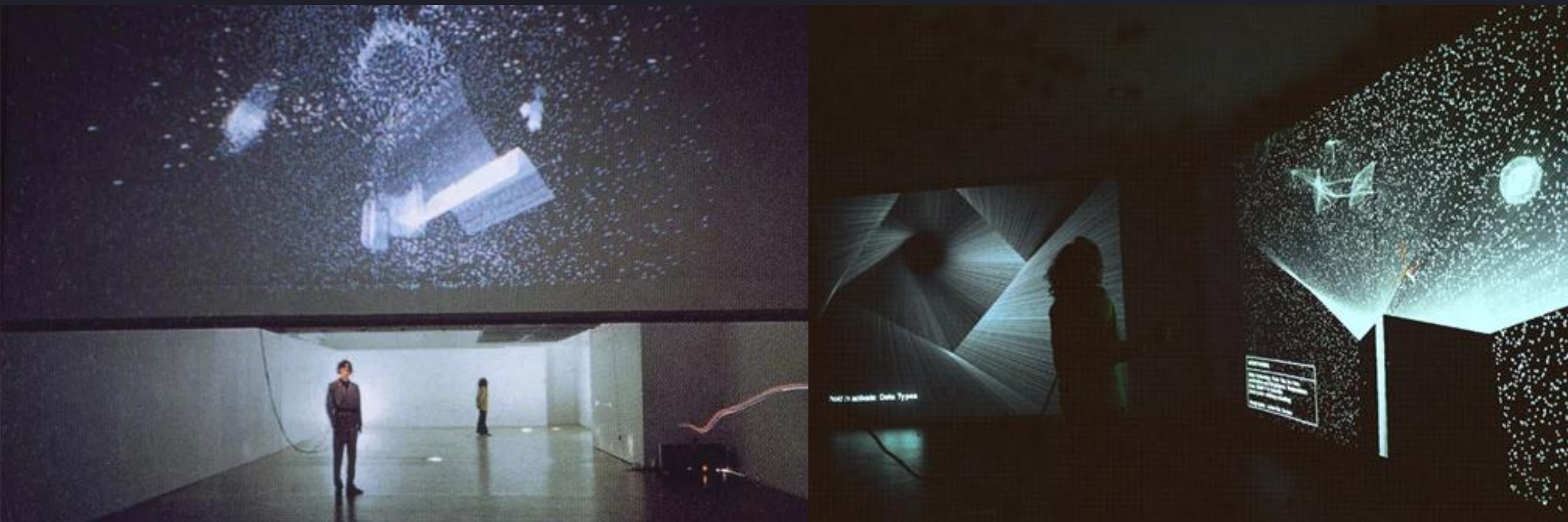
Uncle Roger, Judy Malloy, (1986–1988)



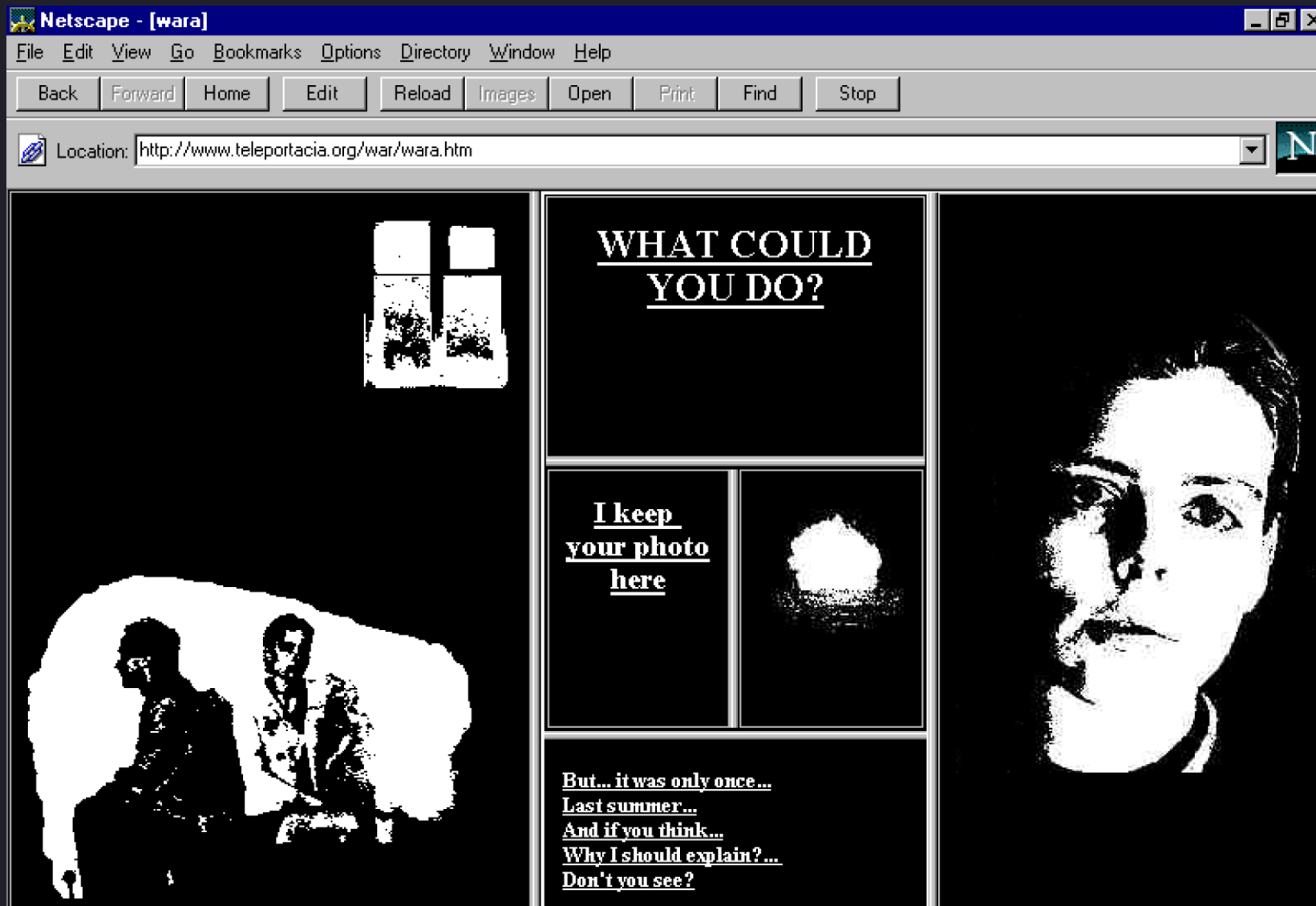
Lev Manovich



Meaning emerges
from the paths users
take while navigating
informational
structures.



Dialogue with the Knowbotic South, Knowbotic Research (1994-1997)



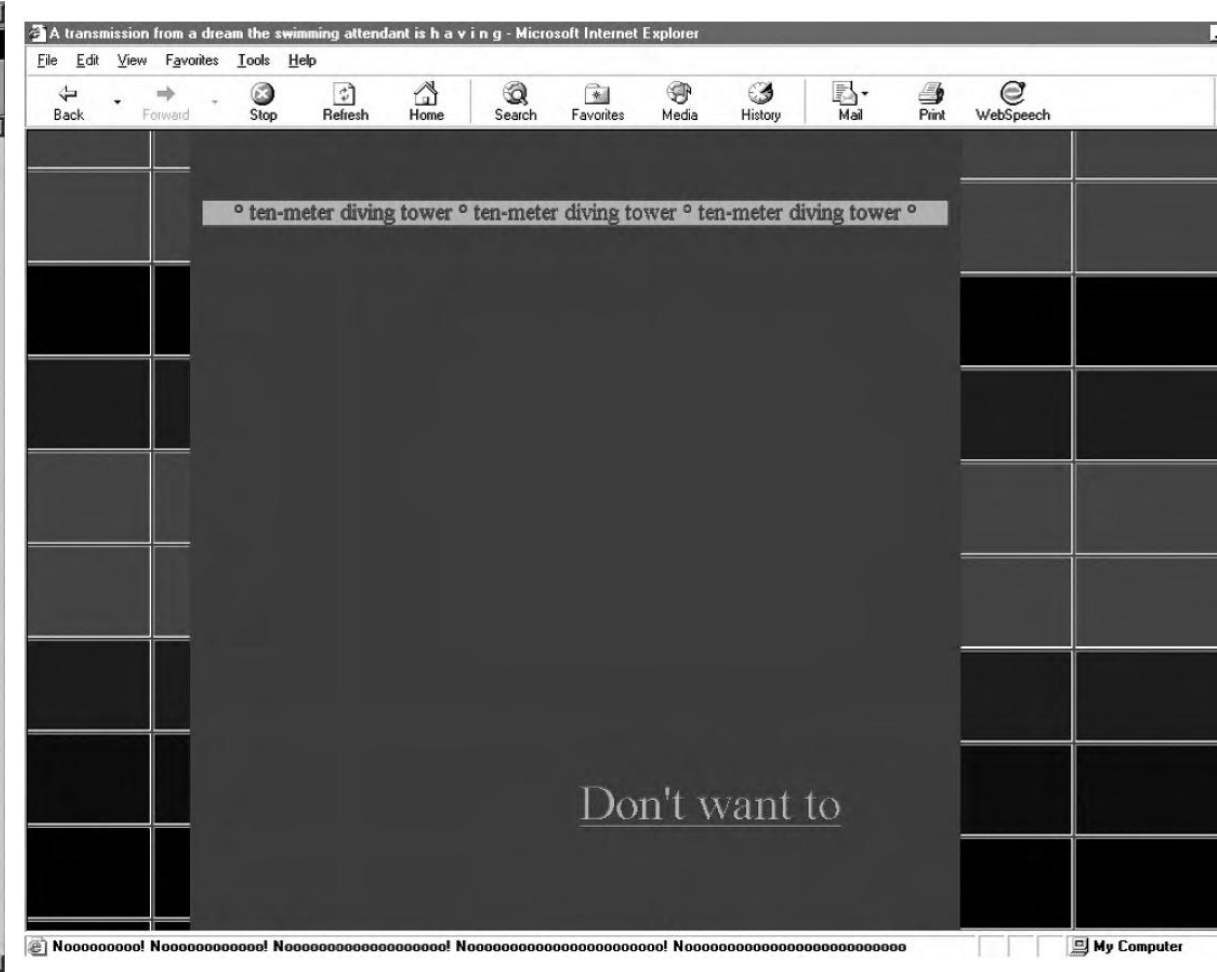
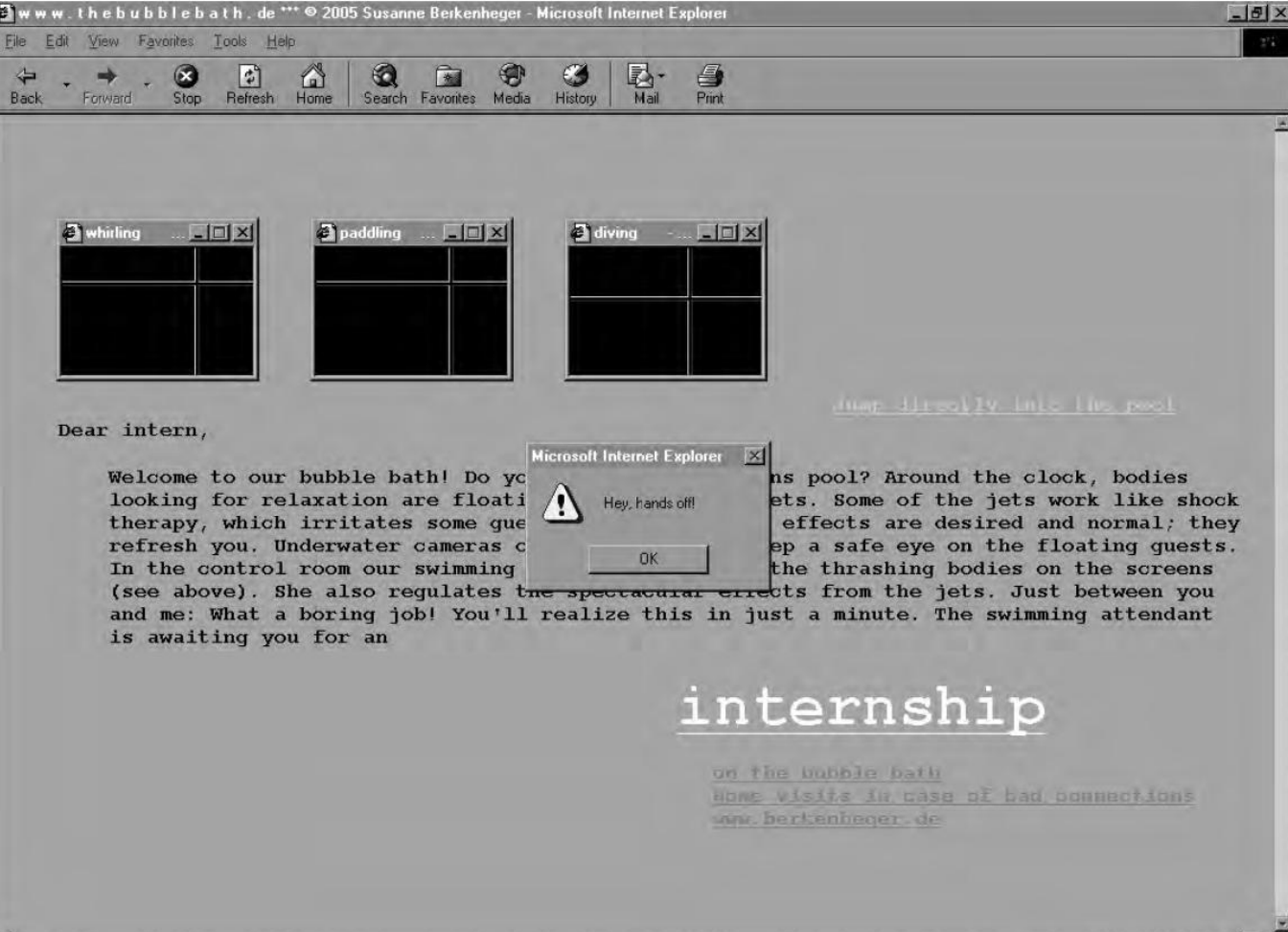
In 1996 typical internet speeds of around 28.8 kb/s meant that GIFs loaded slowly - these pauses unintentionally synchronize with the emotional breakdown of the dialogue

My Boyfriend Came Back from the War, Olia Lialina, (1996)

How could you leverage technical aspects in your work as metaphors—like Lialina's slow-loading GIFs for post-war silences?

Studio Reflections





Bubble Bath, Susanne Berkenheger (1999)

a kind of **trolling machine** in which the interface itself mocks the user's attempts to interact

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Rigid hierarchies shatter: Traditional narratives impose true/false, self/other binaries for illusory closure; ergodic forms demand active traversal to unfold multiplicity (Borges' forking paths).
- Rhizomatic networks emerge: Deleuze/Guattari's web-like structures materialize in digital media—Kac's Reabracadabra hacks state Videotexto control into participatory poetry.
- Database logic redefines story: Uncle Roger and Knowbotic South stage exploration as user/database navigation.
- Interactivity's critique: Berkenheger's Bubble Bath weaponizes browser flaws—revealing corporate traps where "freedom" conditions users to systemic aggression.



WHEN NARRATIVE BECOMES PLAYABLE

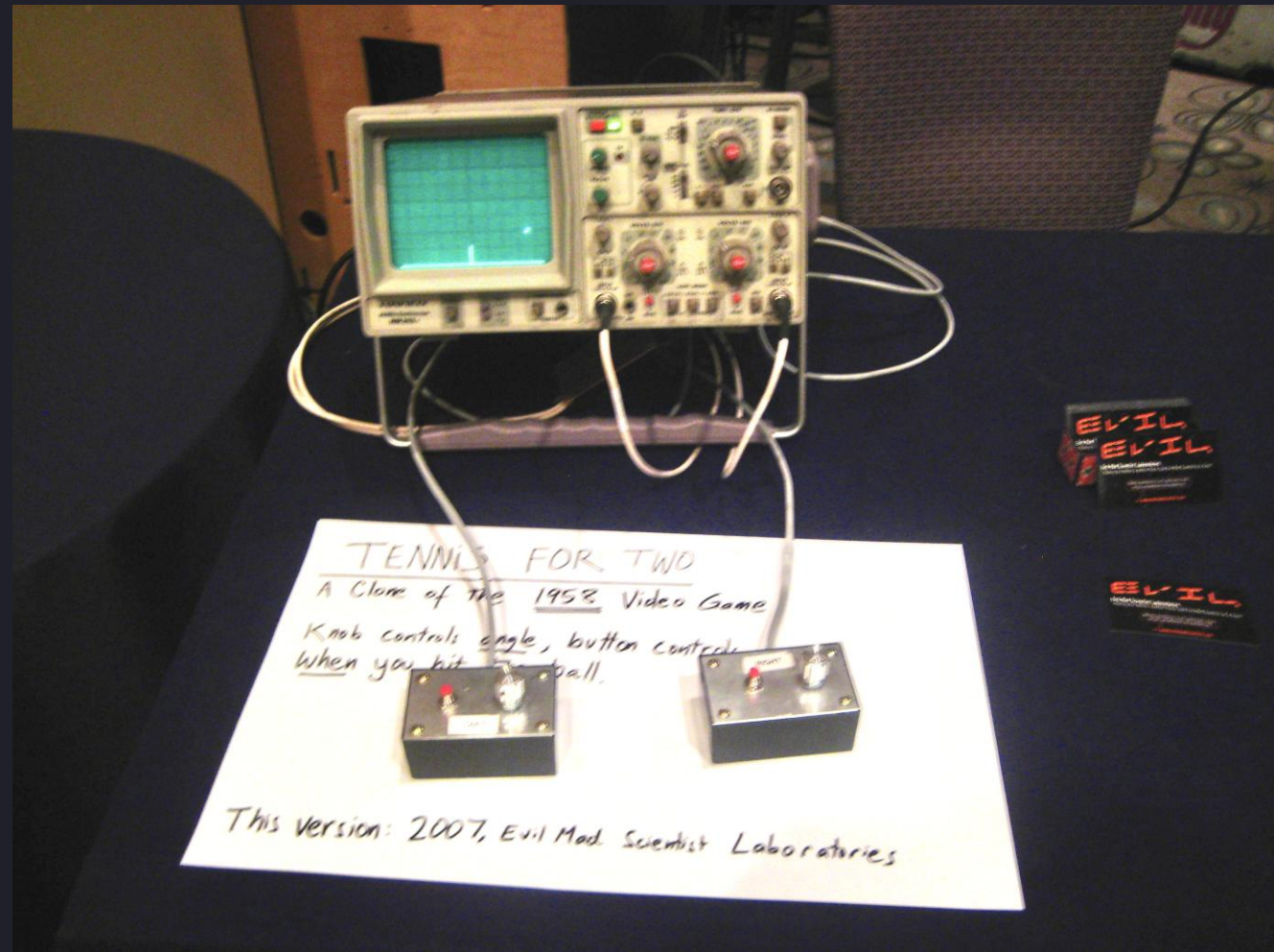
Every action is framed by explicit or implicit rules: there are objectives, win/lose conditions, and systems of reward and punishment.



The roots of interactivity lie in
technological systems developed
for military detection



Serious Games, Harun Farocki (2009–2010)



Tennis for Two, William Higinbotham (1958)



Games are an art form about choices and consequences, actions and outcomes, about using our minds and bodies to learn, understand, and accomplish things.

Frank Lantz





Danielle Brathwaite-Shirley, She keeps me damn alive (2021)

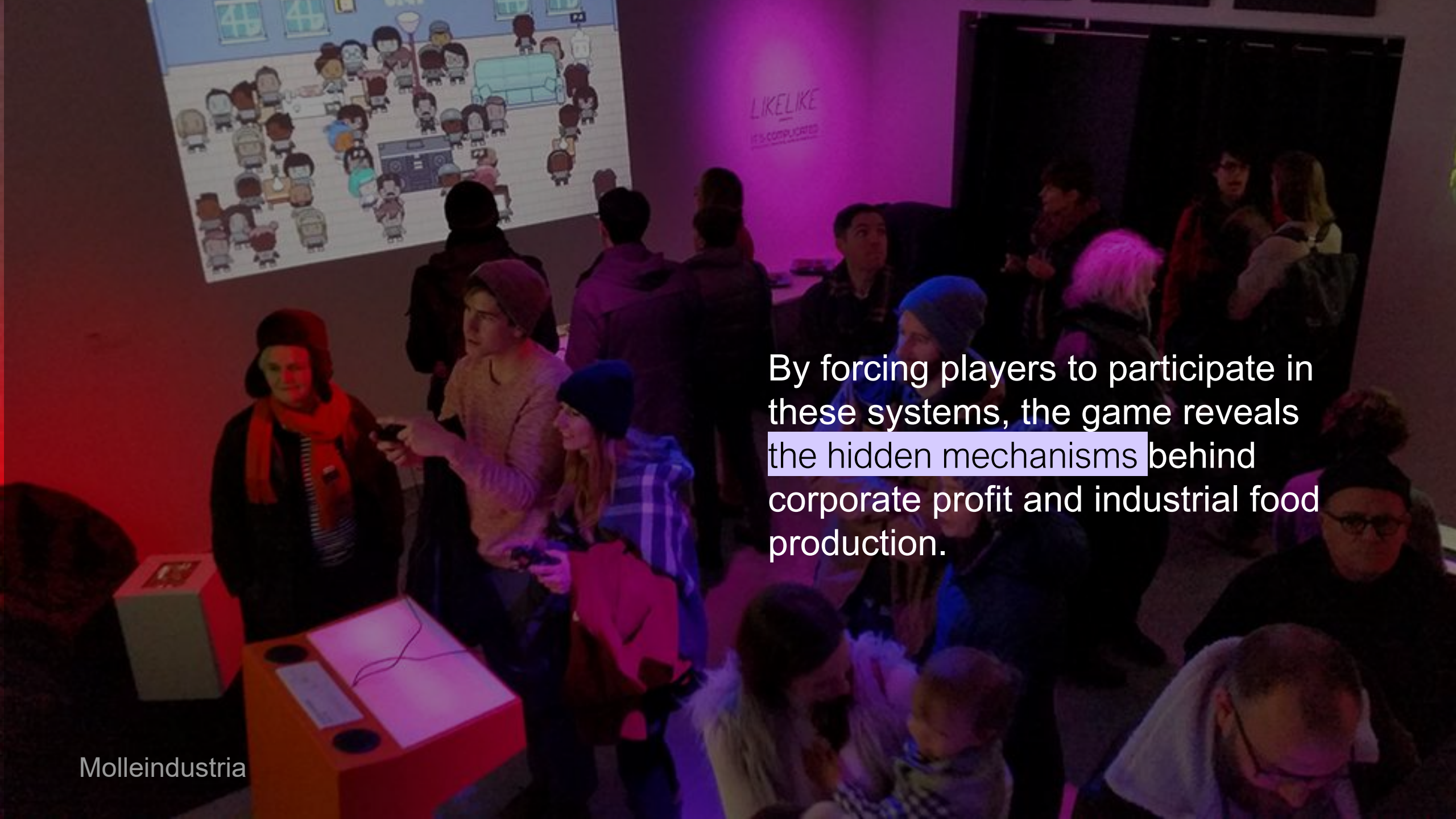
Agency here centers on player responsibility: every shot holds choices accountable, forcing self-examination of biases in distinguishing allies from threats.

VIDEOGAMES ARE POLITICAL

حواجز اللغة

Chella Berman
games journalist & writer





By forcing players to participate in these systems, the game reveals the hidden mechanisms behind corporate profit and industrial food production.

Molleindustria

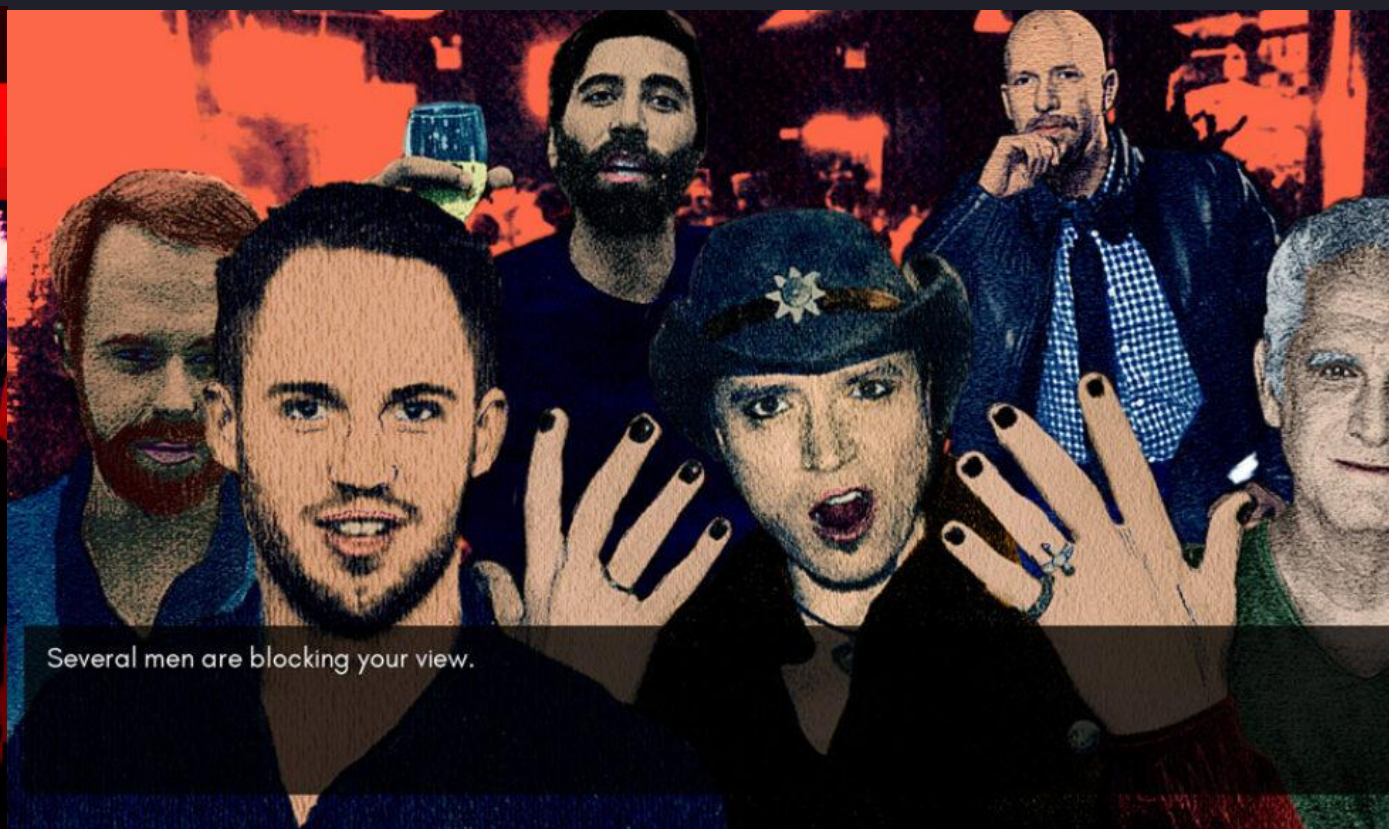
If Brathwaite-Shirley asks: What kind of person are you when you decide?

Molleindustria asks: What kind of system are you participating in when you decide?



... creating a safe space within the game space for rehearsing uncomfortable situations

Angela Washko, The Council on Gender Sensitivity and Behavioral Awareness In World of Warcraft (2012)

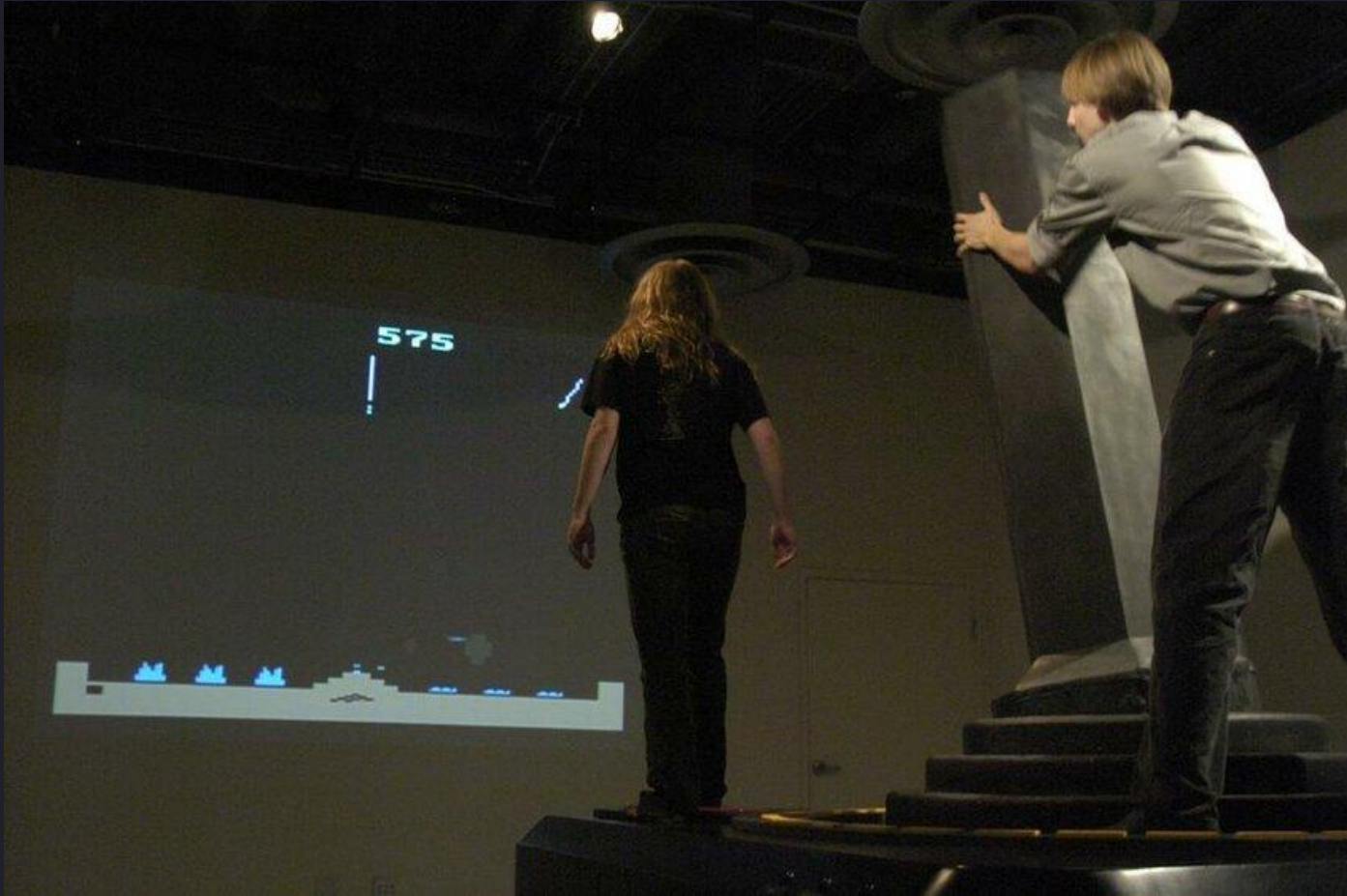


Angela Washko, The Game: The Game (2017)



Theo Triantafyllidis, Pastoral (2019)

... resists the productivity logic, proposing instead a quiet form of digital leisure where the value of the experience lies in the fact that nothing needs to be achieved



from individual control to collective negotiation, as players must communicate and synchronize their movements to influence the game

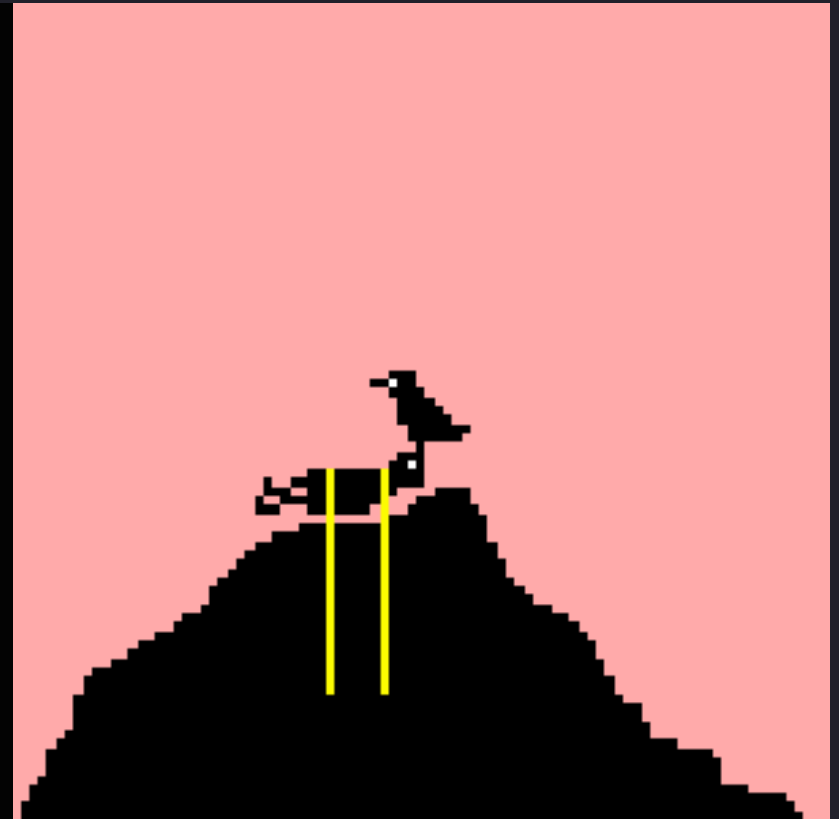
giantJoystick, Mary Flanagan (2006)



The player still moves through the environment using the same controls as in the original game, but orientation becomes almost impossible.



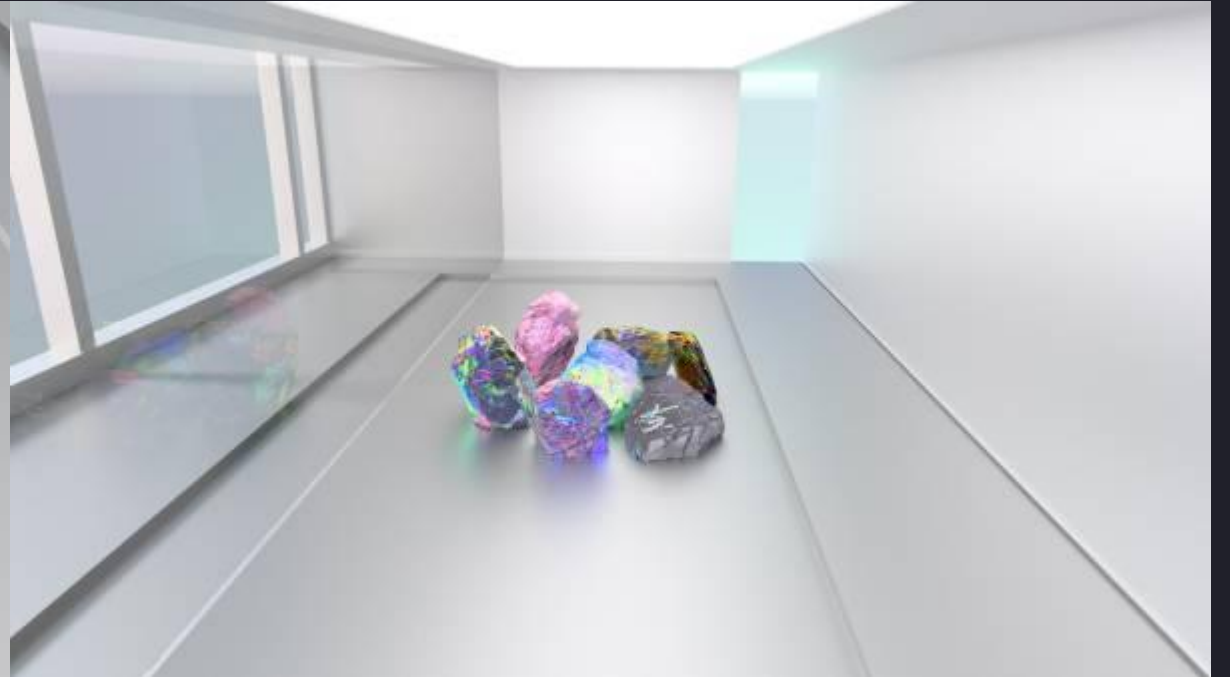
Pippin Barr, The artist is present (2011)



Pippin Barr, Let's Play: Ancient Greek Punishment; One Second Typing Tutor



LaTurbo Avedon, Club Rothko (2024)



LaTurbo Avedon, Panther Modern (2015)

How could you harness gamification trends in your practice—embracing its military-rooted feedback loops for play, critiquing its social conditioning (like Farocki or Molleindustria), or subverting it entirely (à la JODI's broken Quake or Barr's endless waits), any other?

Studio Reflections



KEY TAKEAWAYS

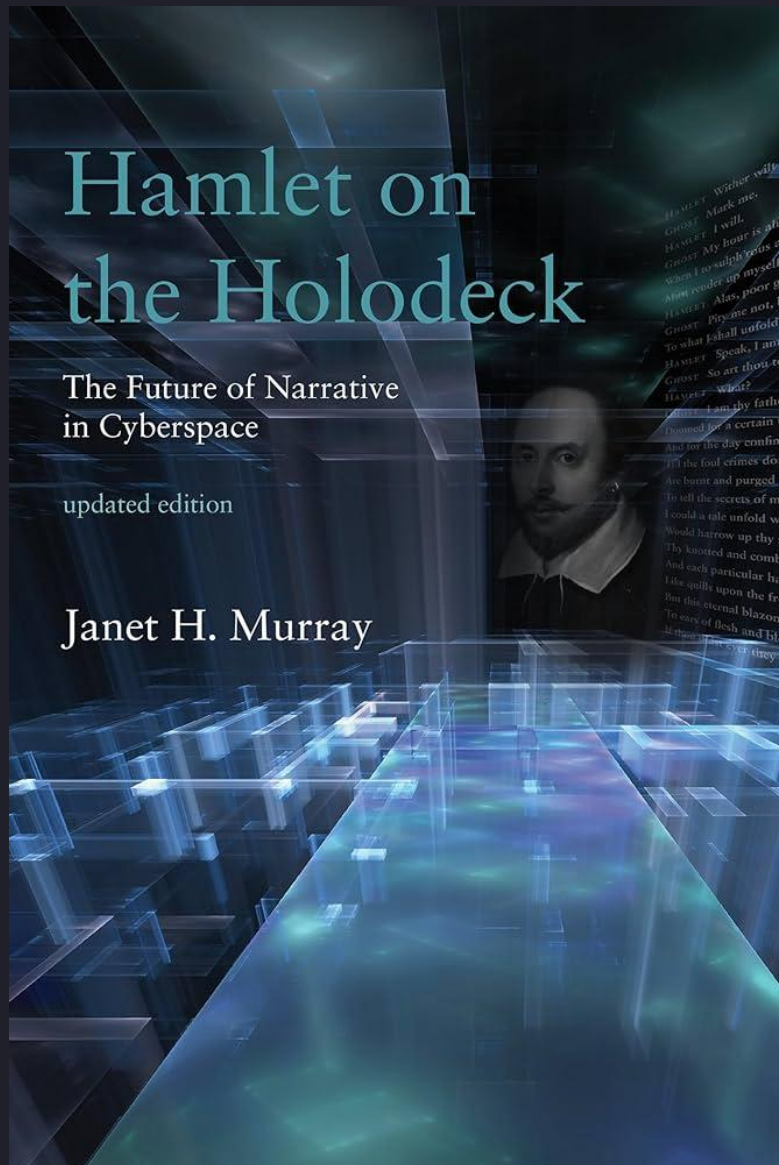
- Interactivity in games emerges from feedback systems between human, machine, and signal. Early technologies such as radar introduced real-time loops of perception, interpretation, and action that later shaped interactive media.
- Games transform the screen from a display into a responsive system. In works like *Tennis for Two*, the visual event exists only through the player's actions, marking a shift from passive viewing to participatory interaction.
- Ethics inside the system. Game art places players inside systems of power—economic, social, linguistic—so that every decision becomes an ethical or political act, not just a move toward victory.
- Play beyond the game. Some works break or suspend the game's logic altogether, turning interactivity into collective, embodied, or unstable play that escapes the imperative to win, progress, or “perform” optimally.

FINAL TAKEAWAYS

1. From meaning as transmission → to meaning as participation. Storytelling begins as a collective act of weaving meaning, where listeners are also future storytellers. Modernity (print, authorship) transforms meaning into something fixed, authored, and consumed.→ The human shifts from co-creator → spectator.
2. The crisis of linear narrative opens the space for interactivity. From Stockhausen to Fluxus to Paik, artists begin to break sequence, script, and hierarchy. Narrative is no longer something you follow — it becomes something you navigate, assemble, and perform.→ The human returns as an active agent inside the structure.
3. Nonlinearity reveals that meaning is not fixed, but contingent. Interactive cinema, installations, and database narratives show that there is no single story — only multiple possible configurations.→ Meaning becomes a result of choices, paths, and perspective, not an inherent truth.

FINAL TAKEAWAYS

4. Digital networks transform narrative into systems of navigation (Net Art) With the rise of networked media, narrative becomes ergodic and database-driven. Users do not follow stories — they traverse systems, assemble fragments, and co-produce meaning.→ But this happens inside infrastructures shaped by power, control, and protocols.
5. Games formalize interactivity as systems of rules, feedback, and consequence. Game art introduces structured interactivity: goals, constraints, rewards. Here, meaning emerges through decision-making under conditions.→ Interactivity becomes a simulation of agency, revealing how freedom operates inside systems.
6. Contemporary interactive art exposes and transforms agency itself. From ethical dilemmas (Brathwaite-Shirley) to systemic critique (Molleindustria) to open-ended play (Triantafyllidis): interactivity is no longer just about choice — it questions: Who decides? Within which system? At what cost?→ We are not simply meaning-makers — we are participants embedded in structures that shape meaning.



the goal of interactive storytelling is to design structured environments where their actions produce meaningful narrative consequences.